

INCIDENT RESPONSE REPORT

SOC344 — EDR Tampering Attempt via EDR-Freeze

LetsDefend SOC Simulation | Prepared for Portfolio Use

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Event ID	322
Alert Rule	SOC344 - EDR Tampering Attempt via EDR-Freeze
Detection Timestamp	2025-09-26 17:26:44
First Observed Attacker Activity	2025-09-26 13:00:47 (whoami.exe — recon, post-logon)
Hostname / IP	WS-Prod-02 (172.16.20.69)
Severity	High
Verdict	True Positive
Analyst Status	Contained

1. Executive Summary

On September 26, 2025, an attacker gained access to the workstation WS-Prod-02 and tried to disable its EDR (Endpoint Detection & Response) protection so their activity would go unnoticed. They used a public tool called "EDR-Freeze," which abuses a legitimate Windows process (WerFaultSecure.exe) to put the EDR's own process to sleep instead of killing it outright — a stealthy trick designed to slip past normal detection.

The attempt was caught and confirmed as a true positive. The affected host was immediately isolated from the network to stop any further damage, and the malicious process was terminated. No signs of data theft or ransomware deployment were found before containment.

This report walks through what happened, step by step, in plain language, along with the technical evidence, indicators of compromise, and recommendations to prevent this from happening again.

2. Incident Details

Event ID	322
Alert Rule	SOC344 - EDR Tampering Attempt via EDR-Freeze
Detection Timestamp	2025-09-26 17:26:44
First Observed Attacker Activity	2025-09-26 13:00:47 (whoami.exe — recon, post-logon)
Hostname	WS-Prod-02

IP Address	172.16.20.69
Severity	High
Verdict	True Positive
Malicious File	EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe
SHA256 Hash	970c7834e58b6ef22473875167a333dbb33bf7b667d1cb814829f68579cd85f7
MITRE ATT&CK	T1078, T1059.001, T1055, T1562, T1562.001, T1489

3. Step-by-Step Attack Story

Here is the incident told as a simple timeline of what the attacker did, and why each step mattered:

Step 1 — Initial Access (T1078: Valid Accounts)

The attacker got into WS-Prod-02 through an RDP (Remote Desktop) brute-force attack — repeatedly guessing username/password combinations until one worked. This gave them a legitimate, logged-in session on the machine. The Level 1 analyst's triage note confirms RDP brute-force activity was observed immediately before the successful logon (see Evidence Notes, Section 7, for what was and wasn't independently re-verified for this report).

Step 2 — Reconnaissance (T1059.001: PowerShell)

Once inside, the attacker opened PowerShell and ran `whoami.exe` at 13:00:47 — the earliest attacker activity independently confirmed in this investigation. This is a classic first move — it tells the attacker which user account they landed on and what privileges they have, helping them plan their next steps. Note that this is the first observed post-logon command, not the moment of intrusion itself; the exact successful-logon timestamp was not pulled for this report (see Section 6).

Step 3 — Defense Evasion (T1562 / T1562.001: Impair Defenses)

The attacker then downloaded `EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe` from a public GitHub repository into the Downloads folder and launched it via `powershell.exe`. Instead of trying to delete or kill the EDR software (which would likely trigger alarms), this tool abuses `WerFaultSecure.exe` — a trusted Windows error-reporting process — to freeze the EDR's process in place using debugging features built into Windows.

In short: the EDR wasn't shut down, it was "put to sleep," which is much quieter and harder to notice.

Step 4 — Impact Attempt (T1055 / T1489: Process Injection / Service Stop)

With the EDR effectively blinded, the attacker's goal was to operate without being detected or blocked — a precursor commonly seen before deploying ransomware, stealing data, or installing further malware.

Step 5 — Detection & Response

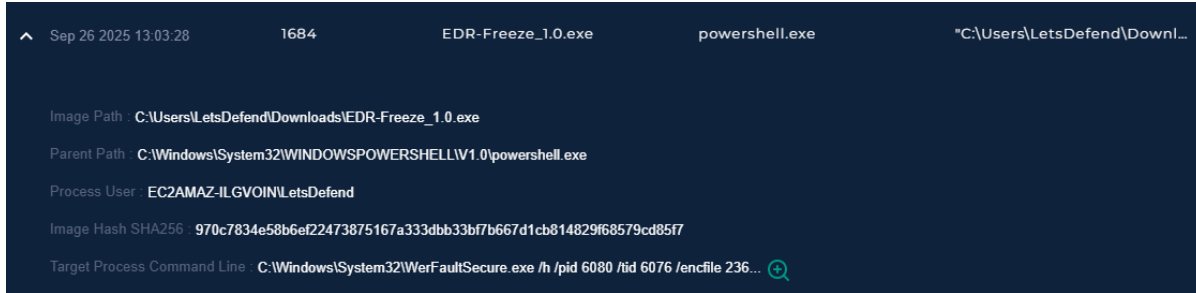
The SOC344 alert rule flagged the suspicious `WerFaultSecure.exe` behavior tied to the EDR process. The analyst confirmed it as malicious, terminated the `WerFaultSecure.exe` process, and contained the host to cut off any further attacker access.

4. Technical Artifacts & Commands

The commands below show exactly how the attack unfolded on the endpoint.

Malicious execution → abuse of `WerFaultSecure.exe` (freezing the EDR process, PID 6080):

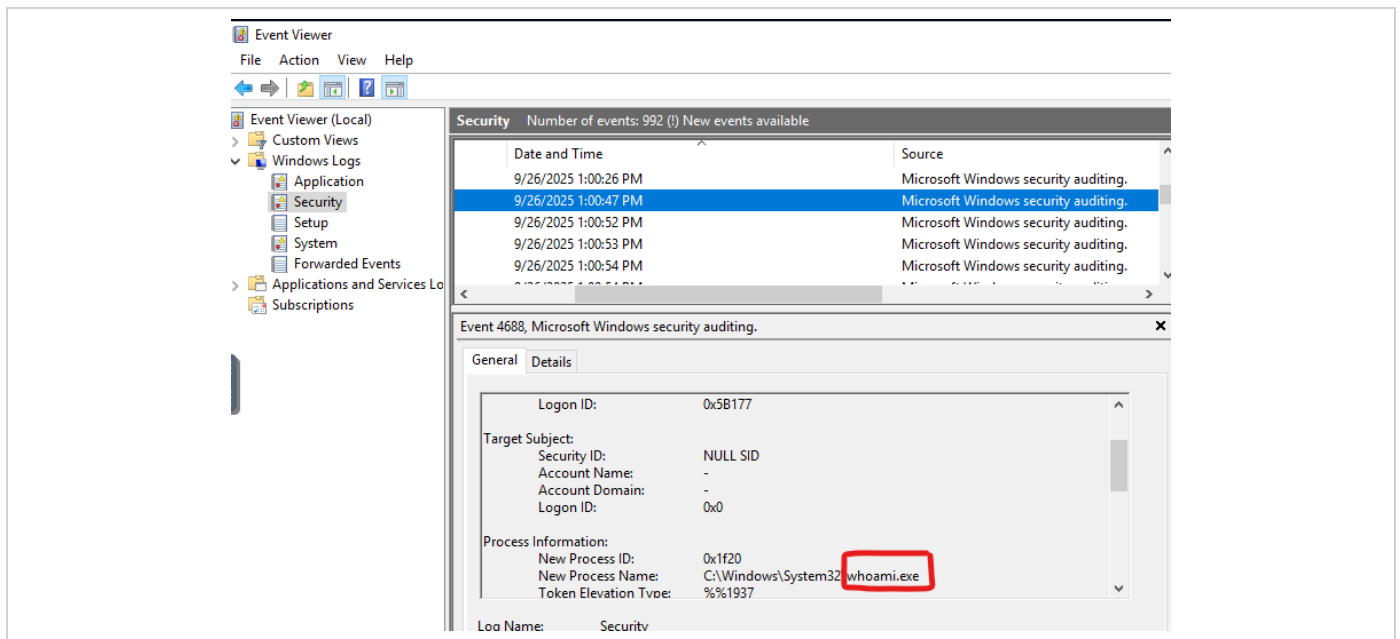
```
C:\Users\LetsDefend\Downloads\EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe 6080 10000
C:\Windows\System32\WerFaultSecure.exe /h /pid 6080 /tid 6076 /encfile 236 /cancel 300
/type 268310
```



EDR log: EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe spawned via powershell.exe, targeting WerFaultSecure.exe

Reconnaissance command (Event Viewer log, Event ID 4688):

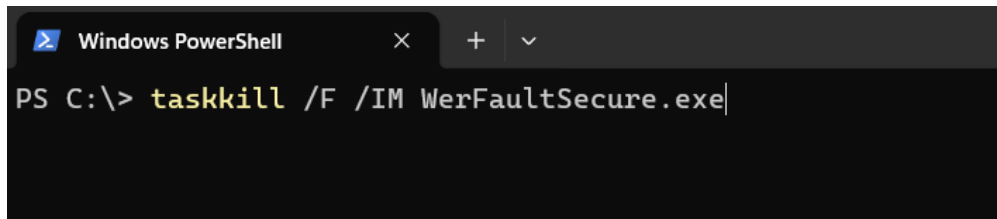
```
New Process Name: C:\Windows\System32\whoami.exe
Logged: 2025-09-26 13:00:47
```



Event Viewer — Event ID 4688 showing execution of whoami.exe

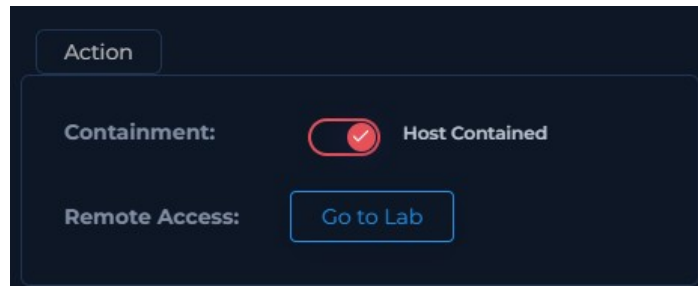
Response action taken by analyst:

```
PS C:\> taskkill /F /IM WerFaultSecure.exe
```



PowerShell — analyst terminating the malicious WerFaultSecure.exe process

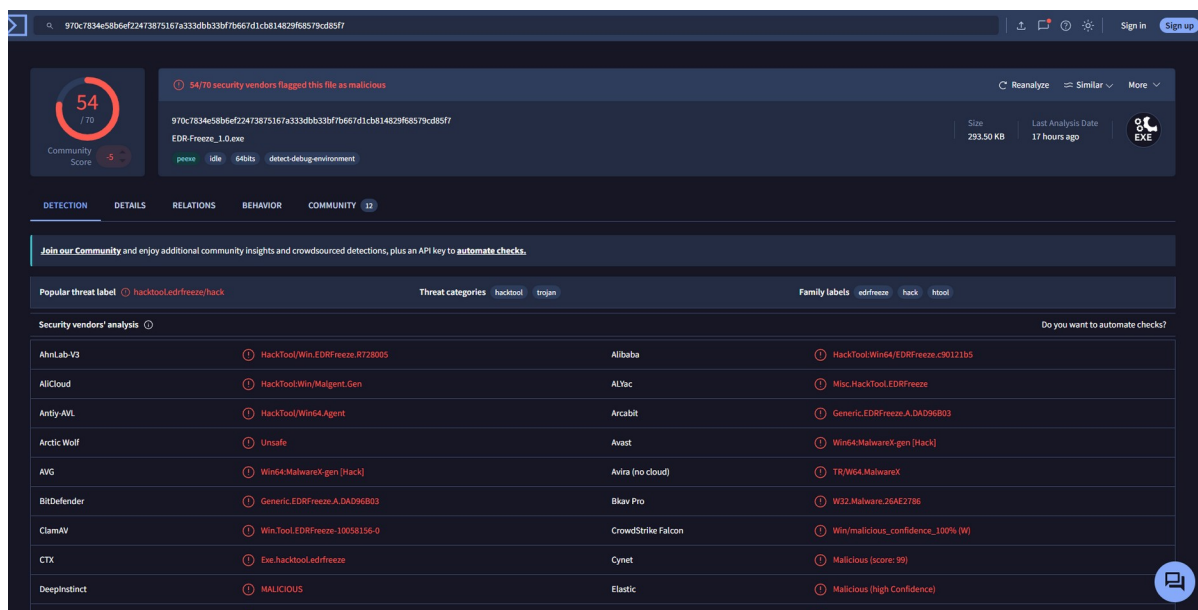
Host containment confirmation:



LetsDefend console — host successfully contained

Threat intelligence lookup (VirusTotal):

The malicious file's SHA256 hash was checked against VirusTotal to confirm it was a known, publicly-flagged threat rather than a false positive.



VirusTotal — 54/70 security vendors flag EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe as malicious

- Detection rate: 54 out of 70 security vendors flagged the file as malicious.
- Popular threat label: hacktool.edrfreeze/hack — file family publicly recognized as the "EDR-Freeze" hack tool.
- Threat categories: hacktool, trojan. File tags include detect-debug-environment, matching its debugger-based EDR-freezing behavior.
- File size: 293.50 KB, packaged as a 64-bit Windows executable (PE format).

5. Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

Type	Value	Context
File Name	EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe	Malicious tool
SHA256	970c7834e58b6ef22473875167a333dbb33bf7b667d1cb814829f68579cd85f7	Malicious tool
Process	WerFaultSecure.exe	Abused (LOLBin)

Process	whoami.exe	Recon
Host	WS-Prod-02	Affected endpoint
IP Address	172.16.20.69	Affected endpoint
File Path	C:\Users\LetsDefend\Downloads\	Drop location
Threat Label	hacktool.edrfreeze/hack (54/70 on VirusTotal)	VT verdict

6. Evidence Notes & Scope

For transparency, here is exactly what this report's evidence does and doesn't independently confirm:

- RDP brute-force (Step 1): confirmed via the SOC Level 1 analyst's triage note, which states brute-force activity was observed immediately before the successful logon. The raw authentication/log data for this specific stage was not captured as a screenshot for this report.
- Timeline precision: the exact successful-logon timestamp (the true moment of intrusion) was not pulled from Security event logs for this report. The earliest timestamp independently confirmed here is 13:00:47 — the whoami.exe recon command — which occurs after the logon, not at the moment of it. Treat 13:00:47 as "first observed activity," not "intrusion time."
- Scope check: the incident was confirmed to be limited to a single host (WS-Prod-02) — no evidence of lateral movement or compromise on other devices was found during triage.
- File origin: per the analyst's IOC analysis, EDR-Freeze_1.0.exe was downloaded from a public GitHub repository, then executed via PowerShell — consistent with the process ancestry seen in the EDR log.
- All other steps (reconnaissance, defense evasion, containment) are backed by first-hand screenshots included in Section 4.

7. Actions Taken & Prevention Tips

Actions Taken

- Identified and confirmed the alert as a True Positive.
- Terminated the malicious WerFaultSecure.exe process (taskkill /F /IM WerFaultSecure.exe).
- Isolated (contained) WS-Prod-02 from the network to prevent lateral movement.
- Collected the SHA256 hash and file path for IOC tracking and threat intel sharing.
- Escalated for further investigation into the RDP brute-force source.

Prevention Recommendations

- Disable direct internet-facing RDP; require VPN + MFA for remote access.
- Enforce account lockout policies to block brute-force login attempts.
- Restrict or monitor use of WerFaultSecure.exe and similar debugging-capable Windows binaries.
- Enable tamper protection on the EDR/antivirus solution so its processes cannot be suspended or modified.
- Alert on any process opening a handle to a security-product process, not just process termination.
- Regularly test detections against known EDR-evasion tools like EDR-Freeze.

— End of Report —